DAAT TEVUNOT: THE RAMHAL ON CREATION, GOOD AND EVIL, AND THE SOUL

What Is the Perfection We Are Aiming For?

Daat Tevunot §19-25

Sefer: Daat Tevunot by Rabbi Moshe Hayim Luzzatto (the Ramhal) **Sections:** §19-25 **Shiur:** Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's series on Daat Tevunot, Wednesday 14 September 2022

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

Review: why create us at all?

The Rabbi summarised the foundations so far. God is good, so He wants to give good. He is perfect, so He wants to give perfect good. Perfect good is found only in Him, and it is impossible to create other gods, so the only way to bestow it is to let creatures connect to Him. We connect by earning it ourselves. When we work for it, the goodness becomes part of us, we are intrinsically good, closer to the divine, and able to enjoy the ultimate good, closeness to Hashem.

"If you don't understand this, stop now," he said. "There's no point continuing." He went round the group asking each to explain it in their own words.

The open question: why not create us without shame?

Last time ended with a question: if the problem with receiving good for free is shame, why not create beings with no shame who simply receive it? Two answers came up. - **A participant's answer:** shame is a symptom, like a temperature with the flu. The root is the relationship. If everything flows one way, there is no real relationship. A parent who only gives, gives, gives does not build closeness with the child; the child just takes advantage. - **The Rabbi's answer:** even without shame, good that you were given is not intrinsic to you, and so there will always be something separating you from Hashem. Compare two people at court: one acts royal, the other is royal. There will always be a split between them. Not even God can make something yours that you did not do. Hashem is good because He is good; we can become intrinsically good only by making the right choices.

The soul asks for more (§19-20)

The Neshamah says: what you have said makes sense to me; continue. The Sekhel then introduces a new principle that follows from the first. Since we must complete ourselves, we can now begin to understand why there is evil and deficiency in the world, what its branches are, and how lack itself serves to complete the world. "Bad to make the world better," the Rabbi summarised. He reminded the group that they come to this with Derech Hashem already in their heads; this part goes back over its fundamental principles.

First define the goal (§21-23)

The Neshamah objects in §21: before you tell me about deficiencies and how they lead to completion, tell me what the completion is. Where are we going? The Rabbi called this obvious: whatever we are trying to reach at the end defines what we are lacking now.

The Sekhel agrees in §22, "kendei barta," you have spoken well, but adds a limit. We can understand the perfection only in general, "bikhlal," not in detail. Still, knowing the goal in general is enough to understand the details of the deficiencies. As a participant put it, how can you describe the details of connecting with the divine to someone still in a physical body? The Neshamah, in §23, asks to hear the general principle.

The perfection: cleaving without a barrier (§24)

"Underline this line," the Rabbi said. The perfection is that a person should cleave to God's holiness and enjoy reaching that level without any barrier or block between them. That is the perfection the book keeps referring to. The Sekhel says it is clear both from verses and from logic.

- **From verses:** Yeshayahu speaks of the future, "you will delight in Hashem," and of seeing His face, and there are many similar verses throughout the prophets. The Hakhamim describe the world to come as having no eating or drinking: the righteous sit with their crowns on their heads, figurative crowns, and bask in the radiance of the Shekhinah.
- **From logic:** the soul is spiritual and its source is God. Like everything created, it wants to return to its creator, as a baby wants its mother, and it will only find rest when it gets there.
- **What it will feel like:** what we will see and think and feel in that state is the detail that cannot be known while we are in the body.

In discussion a participant asked how this could happen in a physical world. The Rabbi explained that this refers to the rectified world with purified human beings, which is olam haba. Can anyone reach 100%? Not even Moshe. As Rav Saadiah Gaon said, if I could fully understand God, I would be God. However close you are to the Queen, even as her son or grandson, there is still some distance. But relative to your own potential you can reach perfection. That again explains how the Torah says no prophet will arise like Moshe, while the Rambam says every person can be like Moshe: you can maximise yourself as he did.

Two side questions came up. Moshe saw Rabbi Akiva expounding the crowns on the letters; the Rabbi said that concerns intellect, not perfection. And the Gemara says four people never sinned and died only because of the counsel of the serpent: Binyamin, Amram the father of Moshe, Yishai the father of David, and Kilav the son of David. He said each case would need looking into.

So what is evil? (§25)

From the definition of perfection, the Sekhel says, we can define the deficiency. If perfection is cleaving to God, then evil is distance from the Shekhinah, and anything that creates a barrier between a person and God, because through that barrier you cannot cleave. That is the bad we have to rid ourselves of. There is one more principle to set out before continuing, and that is left for next week.

A participant suggested that good and bad would be vague without a set of instructions, and that the Torah is that set. The Rabbi agreed: "That's the whole purpose of Torah," and the Ramhal will elaborate on it.

Summary

- Shame is only a symptom; good that is handed to you can never be truly yours, so it would always leave a gap between you and God.
- Having explained the purpose, the Sekhel prepares to explain why evil and deficiency exist and how they serve completion.
- First the goal must be defined, and it can be known only in general, not in detail.
- The perfection is to cleave to God's holiness and enjoy it with no barrier, shown from verses and from the soul's longing for its source.
- Evil is therefore distance from the Shekhinah and anything that blocks a person from God.

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